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CASE STUDY

Hold Button Interaction Design — Bühler Group Machinery Interface

Industrial UI · Interaction Design · Usability

THE PROBLEM

While working on machinery interfaces at Bühler Group, I encountered a recurring usability issue with hold-button interactions. Operators needed to trigger different actions depending on whether they pressed a button briefly or held it for an extended duration — but the interface provided no visual feedback to indicate which action was being registered, or how long they needed to hold.

On a factory floor, where operators work quickly and under pressure, this kind of ambiguity isn't just frustrating — it can lead to errors. Clarity is not optional in industrial environments.

MY ROLE

As the developer responsible for implementing the interface, I worked directly with Figma design files and collaborated with design and engineering stakeholders. Beyond building what was handed to me, I flagged the usability gap and helped drive a conversation about how to fix it.

THE PROCESS

I approached the problem from the operator's perspective — what did they see, what did they expect, and where did the experience break down? The core issue was a lack of feedback during the interaction itself: there was no indication of progress, no confirmation of which action was about to fire.

Working with the team, I helped define two clearly distinct interaction states:

- **Short press** — immediate visual confirmation, action fires on release

- **Long press** — a visible progress indicator (fill or timer) so the operator knows they are on track and how long to hold

This distinction made the interface self-explanatory — operators no longer needed to guess or remember. The feedback loop was built into the interaction itself.

THE OUTCOME

The updated interaction significantly reduced ambiguity for operators and brought the interface closer to the safety and usability standards expected in industrial environments. It was a small change with a meaningful impact on day-to-day use.

WHAT THIS TAUGHT ME

This project made me realise something I had been feeling for a while: I am more interested in shaping interfaces than building them. I found myself spending more time thinking about the operator's mental model than about the code I was writing.

I have spent two years living inside Figma files, implementing designs, and working directly with stakeholders to understand what users actually need. That experience has given me something most junior designers don't have — a deep understanding of what is technically feasible and how design decisions play out in real implementation.

Now I want to bring that perspective to the design side. I am not starting from zero — I am transitioning with context.